New Zealand Prime Minister Addresses United Nations General Assembly

Jacinda Ardern

Ko ngā tangata katoa, e manaakitia ana te whenua, o te Ao Whānui (To all those who care for the lands of the wide world) Ko ngā kaitiaki, e riterite ana, ngā whenua, huri rauna, i te Ao (To the guardians of sustainability around the world) Me tū tatou ki te werohia I ngā wero (Stand and challenge the challenges) I te ingoa o te tika o ngā mea katoa (In the name of what is right with all things.) Tēnā koutou katoa (Greetings to you all)

Mr. President,

Mr. Secretary-General,

Friends,

I greet you in te reo Māori, language of the tangata whenua, or first people of Aotearoa New Zealand. I do so not just because it is the same way I would begin an address if I were at home, but because there are challenges we face as a world that I know no better way to express. Māori concepts like kaitiakitanga. The idea that each of us here today are guardians. Guardians of the land, of our environment and of our people. There is a simplicity to the notion of sovereign guardianship.

For decades we have assembled here under the assumption that we narrowly cooperate only on the issues that overtly impact on one another; issues like international trade rules, the law of the sea, or humanitarian access to war zones. The space in between has essentially been left to us. We, the political leaders of the world, have been the authors of our own domestic politics and policies. Decisions have been our own, and we have ultimately lived with the consequences.

But the world has changed.

Over time we have become increasingly interdependent. We see more and more often domestic decisions that have global ramifications.

Physical events have taught us that in obvious ways: oil spills that show no respect for maritime boundaries; nuclear accidents and testing, the impacts of which are never confined to the exact location in which they occur.